Gastroenterology Service Line Handbook

MERIDIAN HEALTH PARTNERS
INTERNAL OPERATIONS POLICY MANUAL
SECTION: GASTROENTEROLOGY SERVICE LINE HANDBOOK
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OWNER: DEPARTMENT OF OPERATIONS, GASTROENTEROLOGY SERVICE LINE

1. PURPOSE AND SCOPE

1.1 This handbook establishes the mandatory operational standards, scheduling rules, insurance coverage parameters, and clinical scope for the Gastroenterology department across all 14 Meridian Health Partners outpatient clinic sites.

1.2 Compliance with this policy is mandatory for all scheduling coordinators, intake specialists, billing personnel, and clinical staff operating within the Gastroenterology service line.

2. CONDITIONS ACCEPTED AND EXPLICITLY NOT ACCEPTED

2.1 Accepted Conditions: The Gastroenterology department accepts outpatient referrals for the evaluation, diagnosis, and management of chronic abdominal pain, suspected inflammatory bowel disease, chronic constipation, gastroesophageal reflux disease, unexplained weight loss of gastrointestinal origin, rectal bleeding, and surveillance monitoring for Barrett's esophagus.

2.2 Explicitly Not Accepted Conditions: The department does not accept direct scheduling for acute gastrointestinal hemorrhage requiring immediate emergency department intervention, acute mesenteric ischemia, pediatric gastroenterology cases involving patients under the age of 18, or bariatric surgery management. Referrals for these excluded conditions shall be immediately redirected to the acute care network or appropriate sub-specialty clinics.

3. APPOINTMENT DURATION AND SCHEDULING COMMITMENTS

3.1 Appointment Durations: Specialty services within the Gastroenterology department operate on strict time allocations. The standard new-patient consultation requires exactly 30 minutes. Procedural appointment durations are codified as follows: GAST-CONS Gastroenterology Consultation requires 30 minutes; GAST-USND Abdominal Ultrasound requires 30 minutes; and GAST-COLO Colonoscopy requires 60 minutes.

3.2 First Appointment Commitment: The Gastroenterology department commits to offering a first appointment within 9 days of receiving an accepted referral.

3.3 Referral Turnaround: Clinic-wide referral turnaround times are governed exclusively by the Referral Management Policy (MHP-RMP-2021-01); staff shall refer to that policy document rather than applying alternative timelines.

4. PATIENT PREPARATION INSTRUCTIONS

4.1 Consultation Preparation: Patients scheduled for GAST-CONS must bring a complete written medication list, prior relevant imaging reports, and completed intake forms to the facility 15 minutes prior to their scheduled 30-minute time slot.

4.2 Abdominal Ultrasound Preparation: Patients scheduled for GAST-USND Abdominal Ultrasound must maintain strict fasting status, consuming no food or beverages except water for 8 hours prior to the procedure.

4.3 Colonoscopy Preparation: Patients scheduled for GAST-COLO Colonoscopy must adhere to the split-dose bowel cleansing regimen, ingesting the prescribed laxative solution beginning at 18:00 on the evening prior to the procedure and completing the final dose 4 hours prior to arrival, alongside a strict clear liquid diet for 24 hours preceding the appointment.

5. PROCEDURE PRICING AND PLAN COVERAGE MATRIX

5.1 GAST-CONS Gastroenterology Consultation
* List Price: $210
* Duration: 30 minutes
* MERIDIAN-GOLD: Covered, no pre-authorisation required.
* MERIDIAN-SILVER: Covered, no pre-authorisation required.
* MERIDIAN-BRONZE: Covered, no pre-authorisation required.
* CIVIC-BASE: Covered, no pre-authorisation required.

5.2 GAST-USND Abdominal Ultrasound
* List Price: $520
* Duration: 30 minutes
* MERIDIAN-GOLD: Covered, no pre-authorisation required.
* MERIDIAN-SILVER: Covered, pre-authorisation required in 3 business days.
* MERIDIAN-BRONZE: Covered, pre-authorisation required in 5 business days.
* CIVIC-BASE: Covered, pre-authorisation required in 5 business days.

5.3 GAST-COLO Colonoscopy
* List Price: $2,600
* Duration: 60 minutes
* MERIDIAN-GOLD: Covered, pre-authorisation required in 2 business days.
* MERIDIAN-SILVER: Covered, pre-authorisation required in 3 business days.
* MERIDIAN-BRONZE: Covered, pre-authorisation required in 5 business days.
* CIVIC-BASE: Covered, pre-authorisation required in 7 business days.

6. ADMINISTRATIVE EXCEPTIONS AND ENFORCEMENT

6.1 No clinic site manager or scheduling lead possesses the authority to waive pre-authorisation timeframes specified in Section 5 without written authorization from Marcus Vance, Vice President of Revenue Operations.

6.2 Any breach of the 9-day first appointment offering window must be logged in the Meridian Quality Incident System within 24 hours of occurrence.